

An Englishman's Home



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF EVELYN WAUGH

Evelyn Waugh was born in 1903 to a somewhat literary family. His father was a publisher and biographer, and his brother Alec would also become an author in his own right. After attending public schools in his youth, Waugh won a scholarship to Oxford University, where he sought out and gained entrance to the social circles of the aristocratic elite. Losing his scholarship due to poor grades before he could obtain his degree, Waugh dropped out of Oxford and took a series of teaching jobs in Wales, Buckinghamshire, and Notting Hill while publishing short stories and drafting his earliest novels. In 1928, Waugh got married and published his first novel, *Decline and Fall*, an immediate commercial and critical success. Two years later, he converted to Catholicism, a spiritual transformation that impacted the rest of his life. After a stint as a foreign correspondent in Ethiopia and Eritrea, Waugh annulled his marriage, remarried, and moved with his new wife to Piers Court, a country estate in Gloucestershire. When World War II began soon after, Waugh entered the Royal Marines. Although he saw little of the front lines, he did write and publish [Brideshead Revisited](#), his best-known work. After the war, Waugh became increasingly conservative and critical of the modern era. He began to lose both popularity and money, and although he produced many decently received novels after 1945, his expenditures outpaced his earnings, and he died in poor health in 1966.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** An Englishman's Home
- **Where Written:** Piers Court, Gloucestershire
- **When Published:** August 1939
- **Literary Period:** Modernism
- **Genre:** Short Story, Satire
- **Setting:** Much Malcock, a fictional rural town in England
- **Climax:** Mr. Metcalfe and Lady Peabury argue and prepare to leave the village.
- **Antagonist:** Mr. Hargood-Hood
- **Point of View:** Third Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Home as a Castle. The title of "An Englishman's Home" comes from the popular maxim "An Englishman's home is his castle." The saying dates to at least the 17th century, as Edmund Coke wrote in 1628: "For a man's house is his castle, *et domus sua*

cuique est tutissimum refugium [and his house is his safest refuge]."

Bright Young Hypocrite. While at Oxford, Waugh became a member of the Hypocrites' Club, a group of wealthy and flamboyant young men who partied, drank, and made mischief together. Including Waugh, several members of the Hypocrites' Club would go on to be involved with the Bright Young Things, an elite group of London socialites and artists who inspired characters in [Brideshead Revisited](#).



PLOT SUMMARY

In the rural English village of Much Malcock, Mr. Metcalfe goes about his morning routine. As he putters around his house and **garden**, he reflects on his love of the countryside and his eagerness to appear a "true countryman." Having made his fortune as a businessman in the Alexandrian cotton trade, he has only recently moved to Much Malcock with his wife and is keen to fit in with his neighbors. In his upper-class social sphere, he is by far the newest addition—everyone else has lived in the area for 20 years or more. There's Colonel Hodge, a blunt man who has little money but good social standing, especially with local organizations like the Boy Scouts; the Hornbeams, a pretentious couple who make a point of leading a rustic lifestyle and practicing spiritual techniques; and Lady Peabury, a self-indulgent but judgmental widow who owns much more land than any of the others.

While in his garden, Mr. Metcalfe sees two unfamiliar, urban-looking men in his farming neighbor's **cow** pasture. Consulting his gardener Boggett, he learns that they have bought his neighbor's land and must be planning to build on it. Horrified, he hurries to Lady Peabury's house to share the news and consult with her. To his chagrin, she expresses the belief that the land in question had always "gone with" his house and that, since Metcalfe himself ought to have bought the land when he initially purchased his house, he's at fault for the situation. Mr. Metcalfe, who was hoping to propose a plan for all of the wealthy neighbors to pitch in to buy the land back, calls a meeting of all four households a few days later. When he introduces his idea, their response is lukewarm at best, and he finds that they agree with Lady Peabury that the onus is on him to shoulder the full price of the field. He tries to persuade them otherwise, but when Lady Peabury makes a passive-aggressive comment, he loses his patience and shuts down completely.

Colonel Hodge seeks out the man who bought the field and finds him in the local inn. Reporting back to Mr. Metcalfe, he tells him that the man—Mr. Hargood-Hood—intends to build

something worse than a house or even a settlement: an industrial laboratory complete with two chimneys that will pump out poisonous fumes. Mr. Hargood-Hood seems willing to sell, and the price to do so would be £500. In an angry letter, Mr. Metcalfe informs Lady Peabury that he now intends to leave the village and sell his own garden for a housing development unless she splits the cost of the land with him. Lady Peabury's response is haughty and stubborn, causing Mr. Metcalfe to double down. She also resolves to move away, although they both privately feel sadness and regret about the idea of leaving their homes. Their mood reaches the rest of the village, and Mr. Hargood-Hood has a conversation with Mr. Hodge, who proposes a compromise to his neighbors.

In the end, all of the neighbors contribute some money in order to buy the land and build a new lodge for the Boy Scouts upon it, and Mr. Metcalfe and Lady Peabury both stay in Much Malcock. For his part, Mr. Hargood-Hood breathes a sigh of relief, goes home to his own vast country estate, and plans his next target. He and his brother bought and sold the field for a profit in order to maintain their own land; they never actually had any intention of building the laboratory in the first place.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Mr. Metcalfe – Mr. Metcalfe is the most recent addition to the class of landed gentry in Much Malcock, a fact of which he is acutely aware. Before moving to Much Malcock, Mr. Metcalfe spent 15 years in Alexandria, where he profited from the cotton trade as president of the British Chamber of Commerce. For the most part, Mr. Metcalfe is good-natured, if a bit fretful and foolish in his attempts to assimilate to country life. When Lady Peabury insults his pride, however, he leans into his stubborn and petty persona as “Metcalfe the lion of the Rotarians,” a vestige of his years in the cotton business. His new neighbors, for all of Mr. Metcalfe's bluster, are never particularly impressed by his past career. In fact, they often gang up against him and call him names behind his back. “An Englishman's Home” is in many ways the story of Mr. Metcalfe's eventual acceptance into the social club of his neighbors. By the story's end, Mr. Metcalfe seems to be on the brink of surpassing them all in relevance and pride. To his glee, he not only funds the Scout lodge but also succeeds in convincing the local inn to take on his name and become “The Metcalfe Arms.”

Lady Peabury – Lady Peabury is a widow who has lived in a grand house in Much Malcock for many years. She has had ample time to accumulate and enjoy many of life's finer things, including novels, dogs, and lush **gardens**. Moralistic, judgmental, and proud, Lady Peabury is a leader among the village's landed gentry. Her pettiness and pride get her in trouble, however, when she takes a verbal jab at Mr. Metcalfe

and the two end up in a standoff over who will fund the purchase of Mr. Hargood-Hood's field. Their fight makes up the central conflict of the story, and both of them begin to make plans to move out of Much Malcock before they make amends. Ultimately, they are able to reach a compromise by using the newly purchased land to build a Scouts' lodge—and perhaps even more importantly, by naming the lodge “The Metcalfe-Peabury Hall.”

Colonel Hodge – Colonel Hodge is another one of Mr. Metcalfe's opinionated neighbors. Unlike the rest, he has relatively little money, but he has history with and a good reputation in the local community through his involvement with the British Legion and the Boy Scouts. Colonel Hodge tends to be outspoken and critical; he often complains vaguely about socialist politics, for instance, and he makes fun of Mr. Metcalfe's career in cotton while among his own family. Still, he often functions as a messenger and go-between for Mr. Hargood-Hood, Mr. Metcalfe, and Lady Peabury, and it is he who (with some urging from Mr. Hargood-Hood) suggests the compromise that resolves Mr. Metcalfe and Lady Peabury's dispute. Within the group of neighbors, gruff and conservative Colonel Hodge serves as a contrast to the stuck-up, liberal Hornbeams.

Mr. Hargood-Hood – Mr. Hargood-Hood is the main antagonist of “An Englishman's Home.” Although he's quite agreeable and friendly, he's the one who buys Mr. Westmacott's field and consequently incites the feud between Mr. Metcalfe and Lady Peabury. However, he's not the kind and clueless man he seems. The last paragraphs of the story reveal that he and his brother (who was posing as his lawyer) actually bought Mr. Westmacott's field as part of an elaborate con to frighten the local gentry into buying it back from him at a higher price. All of this Mr. Hargood-Hood does in order to preserve his own luscious country estate and **gardens** with the profits. Crucially, Mr. Hargood-Hood's actual background gives him insight into the wealthy neighbors' greatest fears, and he uses these to shape his tricks and disguises.

The Hornbeams – Mr. and Mrs. Hornbeam, who largely act as one unit, are a pretentious and self-absorbed couple who live in the Old Mill and have no children. Mr. Metcalfe counts them among his wealthy neighbors, but as a “borderline case.” Their financial situation is a little complicated: they seem to make very little (if any) money of their own, but Mr. Hornbeam's father sends them enough money to be comfortably upper-class. Their hypocrisy shines in this detail; given that the Hornbeams live off of someone else's money, their disdain for Mr. Metcalfe's cotton fortune and lack of refinement is more than a little unfair. Refinement for the Hornbeams means a homespun lifestyle as a hobby rather than a necessity, and they're interested in casual liberal politics and Japanese spiritual practices. Waugh mocks these two perhaps more ferociously than he does any other characters in the story, and

although they play a very minor role in the plot, they do lay the ground for a lot of incisive social comedy.

Boggett – Boggett is Mr. Metcalfe's gardener. He has only a small role in the story, but as the only speaking character who is not of the wealthy landed class, he is a useful foil for the others. In his efforts to become a "true countryman," Mr. Metcalfe esteems Boggett a little more than he ought. Still, when one can get a straight answer out of him, Boggett is at least slightly more competent in rural matters than Mr. Metcalfe, who can't even read his own barometer.

Mr. Westmacott – Mr. Westmacott is Mr. Metcalfe's neighbor and the initial owner of the field that becomes the Metcalfe-Peabury Hall. He doesn't appear in the story except for when Mr. Metcalfe fondly watches him call his **cows**, but the other characters discuss his conduct. Lady Peabury in particular criticizes his decision to sell his field without consulting his wealthy neighbors.

Lord Brakehurst – Lord Brakehurst is the last of Mr. Metcalfe's named neighbors. "A class apart," he is the wealthiest of them all, and he owns the most land. The name of the local inn, The Brakehurst Arms, suggests that he has sway in the community, too. However, Waugh implies that Mr. Metcalfe is giving him some competition by the end of the story.

MINOR CHARACTERS

The Vicar – The vicar of Much Malcock is the subject of a running joke about his socialist leanings.

downright "indecent." In her eyes, Mr. Westmacott's offense was to sell the field without first consulting his neighbors, all of whom far exceed his own status and means. She doesn't even consider whatever financial need or personal struggle motivated his decision. Waugh drives the point home in the next few lines, in which it looks like Mr. Westmacott's wife will reap the consequences of his actions, as Lady Peabury implies that she will no longer make her the secretary of the Women's Institute. That Lady Peabury would use the Women's Institute, one of her own moral initiatives for the betterment of the community, as a tool to retaliate against Mr. Westmacott's wife underlines both her oblivious selfishness and her pettiness.

The other wealthy neighbors in Much Malcock adhere to the same general idea, and even to their own detriment. After all, Mr. Metcalfe and Lady Peabury's petulant battle of self-interests results in them both spending more money than either of them had intended. Many of the gentry's actions are supposedly performed with the lower and middle-class villagers in mind—indeed, their compromise to resolve the central conflict hinges upon their desire to contribute to the public good and funnel wealth into the community. At every turn, however, Waugh colors his characters' motivation with insincerity and fickleness rather than with a genuine sense of altruism.



HYPOCRISY AND ELITISM

The four upper-class households in Much Malcock react to the prospect of development with comically hyperbolic horror. Their initial fear about what Mr. Hargood-Hood will build on the land is soon inflated into visions of poorly built council houses (affordable, government-owned housing communities for the poor) and bungalows. Mr. Hargood-Hood, who turns out to be a country gentleman himself, preys expertly upon such fears by painting a picture of something even worse: a massive industrial laboratory pumping smog out into the bucolic landscape. The neighbors' disgust at these nightmare scenarios is rooted in two underlying fears: first, that masses of lower-class people will move into the area in pursuit of affordable housing or jobs, and second, that the beautiful countryside they love will be "ruined" and made ugly—two fundamentally elitist concerns that prioritize relatively superficial desires over all else.

Development is presented as an extreme threat to the area's beauty, which is itself cultivated with farms and **gardens**. For Mr. Metcalfe, the image of Mr. Westmacott calling his **cows** in his field is emblematic of this rustic charm, and in this manner, Mr. Westmacott becomes a voiceless symbol of unspoiled land. For Lady Peabury, this symbol of unspoiled land is embodied by her sprawling gardens replete with lily ponds and lead flamingoes—a planned, artificial form of natural beauty. The value that people like Mr. Metcalfe and Lady Peabury place on the landscape stems almost solely from its appearance, which



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



CLASS, HIERARCHY, AND SELFISHNESS

"An Englishman's Home" satirizes the rural English upper class. Every single major character is a member of this socioeconomic bracket, and the

story's humor derives in large part from the petty squabbles and minor injustices within their insular little world. Above all else, Waugh pokes holes in the cliché conception of wealthy landowners as magnanimous benefactors to their communities. In doing so, Waugh calls attention to the petty nearsightedness of the landed gentry: despite their proclamations of altruism, their actions always stem from self-interest and pride.

Take Lady Peabury as an example: when Mr. Metcalfe tells her that Mr. Westmacott has sold his field, her first reaction is to condemn Mr. Westmacott's actions, implying that the sale was

they believe only they are at liberty to control. As existing landowners, they consider themselves part and parcel of the landscape and not impositions upon it. As long as they are the ones in control of the developments, then, they can make them in accordance with their own stuffy aesthetic and elitist principles rather than utility or economy. By highlighting this dynamic, Waugh pokes fun at the gentry's hypocrisy, highlighting the fact that they funnel money into developing the land even though this is exactly what they wanted to avoid in the first place. The only difference, it seems, is that the Boy Scout lodge they build aligns with their idea of what a quaint and charming country landscape should look like. And this, in turn, reveals that their elitist values drive them to behave rather hypocritically, ultimately deciding that they can develop the land as long as doing so benefits them.



SOCIAL MOBILITY

Mr. Metcalfe's long-awaited acceptance into the cult of "true countrymen" at the end of "An Englishman's Home" highlights the characteristics that the story implies truly unify the English gentry: pride, pettiness, and spite. In the beginning of the story, Mr. Metcalfe desperately tries and fails to emulate what he believes to be the markers of a country gentleman, studying aphorisms, choosing outfits, and pulling plants—all to no avail. Nothing he tries seems to gain him entry into his neighbors' social club until he finally loses his patience, gives up, and initiates a power struggle with Lady Peabury in passive aggressive letters. After he contributes a large sum of money to the erection of the Scouts' lodge, Mr. Metcalfe is finally able to cross the invisible boundary between himself and his neighbors and join the ranks of the country gentry. At the story's close, his momentum even begins to threaten the most established inhabitant of Much Malcock, Lord Brakehurst, as he donates enough money to change the name of the local inn from "The Brakehurst Arms" to "The Metcalfe Arms." Ironically, it ends up being the same cotton money that initially set Mr. Metcalfe apart from his neighbors that ultimately greases his way into the fold—they used to condescendingly make fun of his new-money wealth by calling him a "cotton wallah," but his money from the cotton trade eventually allows him to maneuver his way into a position of social prominence. With the conclusion of the story, Waugh satirizes the arbitrariness of minor social boundaries between members of the obscenely wealthy upper class. Between the liberal Hornbeams and the conservative Colonel Hodge, the gentlewoman Lady Peabury and the businessman Mr. Metcalfe, what unites the elite neighbors of Much Malcock and facilitates Mr. Metcalfe's inclusion is not even their desire to improve their community so much as their arrogant sense of self-importance.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



MR. WESTMACOTT'S COWS

To Mr. Metcalfe, the cows in Mr. Westmacott's field represent the simple charm and beauty of country life. They appear for the first time in Mr. Metcalfe's internal ode to the heart of the countryside, sandwiched between lavish descriptions of budding trees and the aroma of wet soil. These, in his mind, are the greatest features of his rural home, and it soothes him that he can see these things from his own yard and imagine himself at their center. In this way, watching Mr. Westmacott call his cows also reinforces his own sense of belonging, which is not at all stable as the story opens. It's no coincidence, then, that when a threat to both the serene prospect of the village and Mr. Metcalfe's fragile authority arrives, Mr. Metcalfe first spots it among Mr. Westmacott's cows. "Unfamiliar figures" in "dark, urban clothes," Mr. Hargood-Hood and his "lawyer" couldn't be more out of place against the backdrop of a peaceful, mundane cattle pasture. Their proposition to build an industrial laboratory in that exact field causes the gentry of Much Malcock to imagine a more extreme, apocalyptic version of the image that Hargood-Hood and his "lawyer" create while standing among the herd. In Waugh's final mention of Mr. Westmacott's cows, Mr. Metcalfe observes the valley with misery, intending to leave Much Malcock and abandon the field to Mr. Hargood-Hood's plans. Watching Mr. Westmacott again call his cattle, he compares their future to his own: "Next week building was to begin and they must seek other pastures. So, in a manner of speaking, must Mr. Metcalfe." Contemplating the cows no longer brings him a sense of joy and belonging, but the fact that Lady Peabury gazes upon her own land on the opposite hill and has the same misgivings ultimately suggests that the cows remind both her and Metcalfe what is really at stake in their squabble—thus setting the scene for their reconciliation.



GARDENS

In "An Englishman's Home," gardens symbolize the gentry's relationship and history with their land. All of the neighbors in Much Malcock have some sort of garden (even the Hornbeams grow herbs), but Lady Peabury's is the most lush and abundant of all. This is no coincidence. Lady Peabury, an aging widow and member of the nobility, has lived on her land for a long time. Thus, her gardens are also larger than everyone else's, a reflection of her family's generational wealth. While her gardens sprawl with fragrant lime trees and aubretias, Mr. Metcalfe struggles to even sow grass in his. As a relative newcomer, he has yet to truly put down roots in the

area, and this bothers him and makes him insecure. The same principle holds in Part IV of the story, in which just as Mr. Metcalfe reflects on the cows, Lady Peabury reflects on her gardens. In just a sentence, Waugh makes the comparison between social and financial stability and the garden: “She was too old now to begin another garden, to make other friends. She would move, like so many of her contemporaries, from hotel to hotel [...]” This is what’s at stake for Lady Peabury: not just her lily pond and lead flamingoes, but the time, effort, and security that they signify. In Part V, it turns out to also be what’s at stake for the Hargood-Hoods. They conned the people of Much Malcock in order to maintain their own gardens, which are in fact finer and more established than those of any other character in the story. In this way, gardens themselves come to represent financial stability, generational wealth, and legacy.

beloved place within a beautiful, peaceful parcel of land. His dedication to his land is seemingly religious, as living in the country is presented as a sort of “initiation” into a “cult.” This language suggests not only the zeal of Metcalfe’s love, but also the exclusiveness of the countryside itself—after all, few can afford to move to a remote corner of England and live the life of a gentleman rather than a farmer.

The syntax and rhythm of this passage also enhance its meaning, creating an almost breathless effect for Metcalfe’s rhapsodizing. The bulk of the sentence is made up of lists of vivid sensory images, and these are often separated by em dashes or semicolons where there might otherwise be periods. This style appears several times in “An Englishman’s Home,” and it always builds tension and marks moments of narrative importance.

The story’s main symbols also both appear here for the first time. Mr. Westmacott’s cows and the flowering groves of trees both initially represent the cultivated simplicity of country life. To Metcalfe, much of their beauty comes from their proximity to himself; he finds comfort and reassurance of his authority while surrounded by the elements of a rustic idyll.

●● Lady Peabury lived at Much Malcock House, whose chimneys, soon to be hidden in the full foliage of summer, could still be seen among its budding limes on the opposite slope of the valley[...]. She was a widow and, like Mr. Metcalfe, had come to Much Malcock from abroad.

Related Characters: Mr. Metcalfe, Lady Peabury

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 220

Explanation and Analysis

This passage is from the first of three descriptions of Mr. Metcalfe’s distinguished neighbors. Lady Peabury is perhaps the most distinguished of these, since she owns the most land, has lived on it for a very long time, and is a member of the nobility. The state of her land reflects both her status and the magnitude of her impact upon it. This introduction makes particular note of her large chimneys, which the plans for the industrial laboratory will faintly echo. The passage also notes her remarkably lush gardens of “suburban splendor,” replete with “budding limes.” Both of



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Back Day Books edition of *The Complete Stories* published in 2012.

Part 1 Quotes

●● For Metcalfe was but lately initiated into the cult of the countryside, and any features of it still claimed his devotion—its agricultural processes, its social structure, its vocabulary, its recreations; the aspect of it, glittering now under the cool May sunshine, fruit trees in flower, chestnut in full leaf, the ash budding; the sound and smell of it—Mr. Westmacott calling his cows at dawn, the scent of wet earth and Boggett splashing clumsily among the wall-flowers; the heart of it—or what Mr. Metcalfe took to be its heart—pulsing all round him; his own heart beating time, for was he not part of it, a true countryman, a landowner?

Related Characters: Mr. Metcalfe, Boggett, Mr. Westmacott

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols:  

Page Number: 218

Explanation and Analysis

This passage, which comes after Mr. Metcalfe’s initial conversation with Boggett, is one of the most important in the story. This is the first moment in which Metcalfe’s passionate appreciation of the countryside becomes clear, and also the first moment in which the story establishes stakes. It’s clear what Metcalfe stands to lose: his fragile but

these details call attention to her own interference with her land. For all that the wealthy families of Much Malcock talk of “preservation,” they don’t seem to preserve their own land. Rather, they prefer to be in control of its beautification and development.

Lady Peabury and Mr. Metcalfe also have something in common: they’ve both moved to England from a different country. While Peabury generally does not mock Metcalfe for his origins to the extent that the other neighbors do, she certainly doesn’t appear to warmly welcome him into the fold—so it’s curious that she must have once been in his position. When the story opens, she seems to sit at the top of the neighborhood hierarchy, and the fact that she reached that point despite once being a stranger to the area foreshadows Mr. Metcalfe’s own ascendancy.

Colonel Hodge lived at the Manor [...] whose gardens, too, backed on to Westmacott’s meadow. He was impecunious but active in the affairs of the British Legion and the Boy Scouts; he accepted Mr. Metcalfe’s invitation to dinner, but spoke of him, in his family circle, as “the cotton wallah.”

Related Characters: Mr. Metcalfe, Colonel Hodge

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 220

Explanation and Analysis

This passage constitutes Colonel Hodge’s introduction to the story. Unlike Mr. Metcalfe or Lady Peabury, he is not wealthy; however, the passage implies that like Peabury, he is well-connected. He certainly has no issue with mocking Metcalfe for the source of his fortune, however. The nickname “the cotton wallah” pokes fun at the mundanity of a job in trade as well as the exoticism of a career in Egypt. That Hodge formulates his insult this way suggests that he’s from a sort of old-fashioned, thoroughly English family. Try as he might to write down and emulate details of dress, mannerisms, and habits, Mr. Metcalfe can’t really achieve Hodge’s level of integration into the community.

But for as much as Hodge appears to address people boldly and directly, talking candidly about issues of finance, he comes off as rather underhanded here. In fact, he functions as a messenger or a pawn for Mr. Hargood-Hood multiple times later on. Many of the other gentry are similarly passive aggressive or phony, and this attitude frequently tends not to work in their favor.

“[...] the Hornbeams at the Old Mill were a childless, middle-aged couple who devoted themselves to craftsmanship. Mr. Hornbeam senior was a genuine commercial potter in Staffordshire; he supported them reluctantly and rather exiguously, but this backing of unearned quarterly cheques placed them definitely in the upper strata of local society [...]. Mr. Metcalfe thought Mr. Hornbeam Bohemian, and Mr. Hornbeam thought Mr. Metcalfe Philistine.

Related Characters: Mr. Metcalfe, The Hornbeams

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 220-221

Explanation and Analysis

This passage introduces the Hornbeams, the last of Mr. Metcalfe’s landed neighbors. Unlike Lady Peabury and Colonel Hodge, the Hornbeams don’t really move the story’s action forward at all. Rather, they almost entirely serve to round out the picture of the upper-class social scene of Much Malcock.

They’re also typically the butt of a joke. The Hornbeams take enormous pride in their homemade crafts and rustic lifestyle, to the point of sniffing at anyone who lives differently—especially Metcalfe, whose career in business they seem to disdain (thus the insult “Philistine”). They themselves, however, rely on the commercial pottery business of Mr. Hornbeam’s father in order to support their little artists’ haven. Like their neighbors, they’re selfish and hypocritical, but they arguably take this further than anyone else. Waugh satirizes their entitlement and melodrama mercilessly throughout the story.

Mr. Metcalfe’s quiet ostracization from the Much Malcock social scene appears more and more petty and pointless. Lady Peabury is “foreign” like him, and the Hornbeams turn out to get their money from a businessman like him. Unfortunately for Metcalfe, no character in this story is self-reflective enough to make this connection.

Foreign visitors impressed by the charges of London restaurants and the splendour of the more accessible ducal palaces often express wonder at the wealth of England. A half has not been told them. It is in remote hamlets like Much Malcock that the great reservoirs of national wealth seep back into the soil.

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 221

Explanation and Analysis

Immediately following lighthearted satirical portraits of Mr. Metcalfe's neighbors, this passage reads rather seriously. The narration also steps back a bit. Whereas the previous paragraph dealt with the minor details of the occupants of one small English village, this one addresses the value of the English countryside more generally. This is an important moment in "An Englishman's Home" because it directly outlines the gentry's justification of its own existence for the first and only time. When the class system is working correctly, this passage suggests, the wealthiest people channel their money back into the community and improve it.

The language in this passage draws a metaphorical comparison between the gentry's massive pool of resources and a natural "reservoir" that waters the soil and allows for fertility and growth. This analogy picks up on the story's larger pattern of characterizing the wealthy as stewards of the natural world, or gardeners; their very presence in a village like Much Malcock theoretically enriches and safeguards the land.

This seems to be the mindset that all of the gentry in Much Malcock more or less share, although Mr. Metcalfe and Lady Peabury both abandon it easily in favor of personal grudges. The fact that they both so nearly ended up leaving the village to "ruin" despite adhering to this worldview does suggest one way in which it is flawed: aside from pride and social pressure, there isn't really any way to hold the wealthy accountable to their side of the bargain.

Explanation and Analysis

This passage occurs just after Mr. Metcalfe and Boggett witness the men in Mr. Westmacott's field. It hyperbolically compares building and development to obscenity and plague to great comedic effect, but it also makes clear just how insular the world of Much Malcock can be. The neighbors have a powerful "us vs. them" mentality when it comes to new people and institutions potentially entering the village. Their outlook in this regard is borderline xenophobic, reducing all those outside of Much Malcock to a threatening image of "fierce tribes." In fact, given the gentry's commitment to their own "improvement" efforts in the village, it seems to be the intrusion of outside influence that they fear more than development itself.

The reference in the final line of this passage is to a 14th-century Italian short story collection, *The Decameron*. In that book, a small group of men and women take shelter together in a corner of Florence in order to avoid the Bubonic Plague that is moving through the main city. This reference, above all, emphasizes the seclusion of Much Malcock as a sort of "safe haven" from the ugly urbanity of the English city.

☞ There was a sudden change. He was no longer the public-spirited countryman; he was cards-on-the-table-brass-tacks-and-twenty-shillings-in-the-pound-treat-him-fair-or-mind-your-step Metcalfe, Metcalfe with his back up, fighting Metcalfe once again, Metcalfe who would cut off his nose any day to spite his face, sink any ship for a ha'p'orth of tar that was not legally due, Metcalfe the lion of the Rotarians.

Part 2 Quotes

☞ *Build*. It was a word so hideous that no one in Much Malcock dared use it above a whisper. "Housing scheme," "Development," "Clearance," "Council Houses," "Planning"—these obscene words had been expunged from the polite vocabulary of the district, only to be used now and then, with the license allowed to anthropologists, of the fierce tribes beyond the parish boundary. And now the horror was in their midst, the mark of Plague in the court of the Decameron.

Related Characters: Mr. Metcalfe

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 224

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 231

Explanation and Analysis

This passage comes on the heels of Lady Peabury's comment about looking forward to "the results of Mr. Metcalfe's negotiations." She regrets saying it as soon as the words leave her mouth, and indeed, Mr. Metcalfe takes it very poorly. The passage marks Metcalfe's transformation very clearly: "There was a sudden change." The severity of Metcalfe's reaction to such a minor snipe underlines the fragility of the gentry's inflated egos (particularly given that Peabury's comment also came from her own unsettled pride). However, one must imagine that this was the last straw for Metcalfe, the culminating event in a long series of tiny insults like "cotton wallah" and "Philistine." In this

moment, he gives up the country gentleman's community orientation and altruism altogether, reinforcing the gentry's association between businessman and private interest.

The long list of epithets in this passage marks a shift from Metcalfe's previous deep reverence for and idealization of the countryside. While the Metcalfe of the past focused on the collective beauty of the landscape and its component parts, picturing himself at the center of a larger ecosystem, this Metcalfe focuses on his own singular drive for profit and respect. The language describing him as a fierce warrior—"fighting Metcalfe," a "lion" who would "sink any ship"—makes for a humorous contrast with the bumbling, weed-pulling Metcalfe of the story's early pages, and the difference highlights his lack of self-insight.

Part 3 Quotes

☛ He wants £500. It is excessive, but I am prepared to pay half of this if you will pay the other half. Should you not accede to this generous offer I shall take steps to safeguard my own interests at *whatever cost to the neighbourhood...*

P.S. —I mean I shall sell the Hall and develop the property *as building lots*.

Related Characters: Mr. Metcalfe (speaker), Lady Peabury

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 233

Explanation and Analysis

This section of the story, in which Mr. Metcalfe "going to war" with Lady Peabury consists of writing her a strongly worded letter, really drives the pettiness of the whole fight home. At the same time, though, the stakes have gone up, as Mr. Hargood-Hood wants £500, a marked increase from the £170 for which the land originally sold.

Mr. Metcalfe's ultimatum to Lady Peabury puts her in the position of choosing which of his personas he will be: the "generous" countryman, or the man who "safeguard[s] his] own interests." Of course, his offer to split the bill with her likely has more to do with getting her to back down than offering a true compromise, and for that reason, Peabury won't accept. Metcalfe's attempt to be menacing and subtle in the last line of his letter characteristically fails when he adds a postscript saying exactly what he means: he's willing to develop building lots, perhaps even council houses, on his property just to spite Peabury.

This represents a complete reversal of his earlier efforts to preserve the land, and it does beg the question: was it ever

about preservation, or was it about blending in with the other neighbors? Of course, Metcalfe now plans to move away from Much Malcock altogether, so the value that the land once held for him as a visual paradise is soon to be destroyed.

Part 4 Quotes

☛ In the doomed field Mr. Westmacott, almost for the last time, was calling his cattle; next week building was to begin and they must seek other pastures. So, in a manner of speaking, must Mr. Metcalfe.

Related Characters: Mr. Metcalfe, Mr. Westmacott

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 234

Explanation and Analysis

This passage takes place 10 days after Mr. Metcalfe and Lady Peabury's exchange of letters. Metcalfe looks out over the valley and mourns its impending ruin, picturing near-apocalyptic visions of smog and withering greenery. As he watches Mr. Westmacott's cattle, he works them into this line of thought, considering their field "doomed" and thinking that, like himself, the cows will be displaced and forced to move.

This moment marks the final stage in the symbolic development of the cows in "An Englishman's Home." They had always been part of Metcalfe's country rituals, but now, as the threat against them that he perceived while watching Hargood-Hood stand among them in their field becomes concrete, he associates them closely with himself. On the eve of building, watching the cows reminds him painfully that he stands to lose the home he loves because of his own pride and folly.

☛ The great shadows of the cedars lay across the lawn; they had scarcely altered during her long tenancy, but the box hedge had been of her planting; it was she who had planned the lily pond and glorified it with lead flamingoes [...] the flowering shrubs were hers; she could not take them with her where she was going. Where? She was too old now to begin another garden, to make other friends. She would move, like so many of her contemporaries, from hotel to hotel [...].

Related Characters: Lady Peabury**Related Themes:**  **Related Symbols:** **Page Number:** 234**Explanation and Analysis**

This passage occurs after Mr. Metcalfe looks out upon the valley. From the opposite side, Lady Peabury is doing the exact same thing, and her thoughts are following a similar thread. While Metcalfe reflects upon the cows, Peabury reflects upon her gardens. The essence of both symbols lies in the idea of *cultivated* beauty—like the cows, the gardens are domesticated, representing human influence upon the landscape. Peabury's gardens are particularly majestic (Metcalfe considers them full of “suburban splendor”) and well-established. Her cedars are tall, a testament to her “long tenancy,” and her gardens are full of flourishes that reinforce her own sense of grandeur and “glorify” the land.

Lady Peabury's garden is the work of many years, a “preservation” effort and a beautification effort at once. She has poured so much time into it that it has become symbolic of her personal history and domestic stability. At this point in the story, she faces the prospect of leaving Much Malcock, just as Metcalfe plans to do. Given her age and finances, however, the move would likely be much harder for her—as she laments, she would have to live an itinerant lifestyle with no sense of place or permanence.

While it doesn't end up happening, the future that Lady Peabury contemplates is grim to consider. “An Englishman's Home” is usually lightheartedly critical of the wealthy and their whims, but in this moment, the upper-class Lady Peabury faces a somewhat depressing future (albeit because of her own pride).

Part 5 Quotes

☞ They drove to Mr. Hargood-Hood's home, a double quadrangle of mellow brick that was famous far beyond the county. On the days when the gardens were open to the public, record crowds came to admire the topiary work, yews and boxes of prodigious size and fantastic shape which gave perpetual employment to three gardeners. Mr. Hargood-Hood's ancestors had built the house and planted the gardens[...]. A sterner age demanded more strenuous efforts for their preservation.

Related Characters: Mr. Hargood-Hood**Related Themes:**  **Related Symbols:** **Page Number:** 236-237**Explanation and Analysis**

This passage finally reveals Mr. Hargood-Hood's con: he bought and resold Mr. Westmacott's field at a profit so that he could fund landscaping efforts for his own country estate. The Hargood-Hoods' property appears to be at least as grand as Lady Peabury's, and likely more so. After all, tourists visit their land just to gawk at their gardens. Gardens function symbolically here in the same way as they do throughout the rest of the story. In this case, Mr. Hargood-Hood's ancestors planted his gardens, implying that his history and authority over his land is particularly well-established.

Mr. Hargood-Hood's scheme to trick the gentry of Much Malcock out of their money is certainly selfish, but he justifies it with the exact same set of principles that the other gentry use: “preservation” and community good. It is important, for instance, that his three gardeners keep their jobs. In fact, Mr. Hargood-Hood embodies the story's ideal theory of the English class system perhaps more literally than anybody else, since he funnels “his” money directly back into the land in order to maintain his ponds and topiaries.

Of course, it isn't really *his* money—but to him, Much Malcock is simply another “fierce tribe” outside of the boundaries of his own home.

☞ Together the two brothers unfolded the inch ordnance map of Norfolk, spread it on the table of the Great Hall and began their preliminary, expert search for a likely, unspoilt, well-loved village.

Related Characters: Mr. Hargood-Hood**Related Themes:**  **Page Number:** 237**Explanation and Analysis**

This passage follows on the heels of the description of the Hargood-Hood estate. Apparently, the brothers have been at this game for some time now, and they have it down to a

science. The characteristics that they seek out in a village are just those in which Mr. Metcalfe reveled at the beginning of the story: it should be “unspoilt” and surrounded by country gentry who are invested in its future. The same qualities that make these corners of the English countryside so pleasant to people like Mr. Metcalfe also make them vulnerable to exploitation. Of course, “An Englishman’s Home” raises several different ideas about what “exploitation” of the land can mean, and by the end of the story, the word seems more subjective than ever. Although the story ends with a comedic twist, there is

something a little queasy about this finale. An earlier quotation about the Hargood-Hood estate mentions the “sterner age” that motivates the Hargood-Hoods to prey upon other properties in order to strengthen their own, and as the story draws to a close, one is left pondering the effects of modernity upon the rural upper classes. Colonel Hodge’s complaints about the “Bolshies” are mostly played for laughs, but the ending of this tale could prompt a reading that seriously considers the future of the English class system and its potential effects upon the picturesque, moneyed world of the countryside.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

PART 1

Mr. Metcalfe observes the barometer in his fine country home. He is deeply interested in the habits and behaviors of “true countrymen,” which he obsessively notes and aspires to replicate. Thus, he seeks out his gardener, Boggett, and cheerfully informs him that it looks like rain—after all, that’s what a true countryman would do. Outside, however, the sky is clear and blue. As Metcalfe and Boggett discuss the weather, Metcalfe allows his short-spoken peasant gardener the final word in the conversation. He values salt-of-the-earth types like Boggett, especially since he has only recently moved to the countryside. Metcalfe adores his beautiful new property and his new role as its owner.

Metcalfe muses about the size of his land, which is relatively modest. Still, he is pleased with his seven acres of “unspoilt” land and the “dignified” house that sits upon it, especially since he could have afforded more, but chose a more manageable and profitable amount of land to own. Having made his fortune in the cotton trade in Alexandria, he is especially eager to integrate into the English pastoral lifestyle. Although the local villagers in Much Malcock have called this house “Grumps” for decades, Metcalfe is fussily insistent that everybody call it “Much Malcock Hall” instead.

The opening passage establishes that Mr. Metcalfe is an enthusiastic and well-meaning, if rather inept, student of the country lifestyle. His admiration of the lower-class, apathetic Boggett hints at his surface-level geniality, and his apparent misreading of his barometer establishes his own cluelessness. Simply owning land, the story gently implies, doesn’t necessarily make Mr. Metcalfe a “true countrym[a]n.”



Metcalfe’s perspective on land ownership is that of the businessman he once was: he’s primarily concerned with return on investment. However, the return he gets, in this case, has more to do with his romanticized image of the tranquil and picturesque English countryside than it has to do with financial concerns. Metcalfe’s attempts to rename his estate represent another one of his efforts to establish and control his own image within the larger community; like his neighbors, the name “Grumps” predates him and has greater local authority.



There are three other prominent households in Metcalfe's area. They belong to Lady Peabury, Colonel Hodge, and Mr. and Mrs. Hornbeam, respectively. Lady Peabury is a widow who enjoys creature comforts that hint at her wealth and heritage: cultivated **gardens**, novels, dogs, and porcelain. She lives in Much Malcock House. Colonel Hodge doesn't have much money, but he's active in prestigious community organizations. He calls Metcalfe dismissive names ("the cotton wallah") behind his back, and he also lives in a fine home: the Manor. Lastly, despite being on relatively equal footing with the other households in income, the Hornbeams stand apart because of their affectedly rustic, artistic lifestyle. They live at the Old Mill.

Metcalfe's neighbors are all caricatures of the English upper classes. They differ in their habits and income, but unlike Metcalfe, all of them have lived in Much Malcock for decades and have become part of its community. In this section, it becomes clear that Metcalfe's insecurities are justified; both Colonel Hodge and the Hornbeams look down on his business career and criticize him in the company of others. Hodge's name for Metcalfe, "the cotton wallah," combines several insults into one. "Wallah" is an Indian English word for a person with any duty, but Englishmen in this period particularly often used it in relation to Indian service professions, and it tends to be derogatory in certain applications. When Hodge says it, the word underlines the financial motivation of Metcalfe's career, compares it to lower-class trades, and draws attention to his foreignness relative to his new neighbors in the English countryside. Of course, this section also sets up the flaws and hypocrisies of Metcalfe's neighbors. Peabury is self-indulgent, Hodge poor and brash, and the Hornbeams leechlike and pretentious.



The villagers of Much Malcock benefit from the combined presence of these wealthy households. The rich funnel their money into community buildings and organizations, and the town residents are comfortable and satisfied with their quality of life. At Much Malcock Hall, Metcalfe carefully oversees the household chores before finishing his morning routine with breakfast and the newspaper. At breakfast, his wife scoffs at his report of his conversation with Boggett, calling the gardener's advice "nonsense." As Metcalfe settles into his newspaper, the first section of the short story concludes with a humorously hyperbolic forewarning of the conflict to come.

"An Englishman's Home" frequently revisits the idea of the wealthier classes using their money to protect the welfare of their larger communities. This passage introduces an ideal vision of how this principle should work: the gentry build and preserve common buildings and care for the town financially, and the peasantry go about their work and maintain the status quo. In this way, they uphold the class system. As the expression referenced in the title suggests, each wealthy household views their responsibility to the villagers as not unlike that of a ruler to their subjects; it's their job to control, preserve, and beautify their kingdoms.



PART 2

Metcalfe moves on to a bit of light yardwork, attempting to pull some plants from his lawn so that he can plant new grass there instead. Boggett passes by and Metcalfe calls out to him, showing him his work and asking for input—only to be disappointed when Boggett finally informs him that the plants will grow back no matter what. When Metcalfe looks up, he notices two unfamiliar young men in "urban clothes" inspecting a neighboring field full of **cows**. Upon summoning Boggett again, Metcalfe learns that a neighboring farmer has sold his land to a man from London, who, Metcalfe and Boggett surmise, must want to build a house upon it. Metcalfe is horrified at the thought of the land being developed and resolves to act.

Gardening is yet another method by which Metcalfe attempts to pass as a genuine countryman. But it certainly doesn't come easily to him, as even the landscape seems to resist his influence. When he looks up from his work, he notices a threatening image of discord: city men in Westmacott's field. Part of Metcalfe's dismay at the sight comes from the fact that he considers Mr. Westmacott's cows to be symbols of pastoral simplicity itself, elements of the countryside that he sees from his property every day. Metcalfe's horror is comically exaggerated, though. At this point, Metcalfe and the gentry are imagining a new house on Mr. Westmacott's field, and their disgust at the idea suggests that their fear of development may be rooted in their aversion to outsiders in addition to their aesthetic and environmental concerns.



Metcalfe pays a visit to Lady Peabury and somberly explains the situation to her. She is as disturbed by the news as Metcalfe is, but she soon looks for someone to blame for the state of affairs. First, she turns to the farmer who sold the land, implying that it was indecent of him to make the sale without checking in with the upper-crust community nearby. Soon, though, she turns her attention to Metcalfe himself, scolding him for not buying the plot of land along with his original purchase of Much Malcock Hall. In fact, she seems to think he should buy it now. After all, everybody has always associated the land with Metcalfe's property, even if he didn't buy it when he originally moved to Much Malcock.

Colonel Hodge is waiting at the Hall when Metcalfe returns, having already heard the news. Like Peabury, he mentions that he feels the sold land ought to have been part of Metcalfe's property from the start. He mourns the arrival of an entire housing development of bungalows or villas sure to come from the urban men's building plan, but Metcalfe still hopes to prevent them from breaking ground through bureaucratic means. Meanwhile, at the Old Mill, the Hornbeams receive word of the situation and react with melodramatic despair. Mr. Hornbeam laments the plight of the solitary Artist in a world that is increasingly urban and industrial, and he grouses that their hopes for salvation depend on the actions of Metcalfe, whom they consider unrefined and nouveau riche.

Metcalfe calls a meeting of the neighbors at Much Malcock House. The others have agreed that Metcalfe should be the one to buy the land in order to preserve it, but Metcalfe is still pushing to split the bill. He proposes that they each pay an amount proportional to the amount of land they own, which would leave Peabury paying the lion's share, Metcalfe and Hodge each paying much less, and the Hornbeams paying half of that. Even with expectations so low, Hodge and the Hornbeams immediately refuse. Peabury, on the other hand, feels stuck in the bargain even though Metcalfe has more money than she does, since she refuses to lower herself by pointing out this fact.

Lady Peabury is quick to judge, and it doesn't take long before she tries to blame others for the impending development of Westmacott's field. Her conviction that Metcalfe should have bought the field along with his house ultimately highlights that she thinks it's her right to control the shape of the landscape around her. And this, in turn, demonstrates the ways in which wealthy people in this story feel entitled to make sweeping decisions about the surrounding world.



While Hodge and the Hornbeams' reactions to Metcalfe's news vary in their particulars, they all share the same dramatic sense of dread at the prospect of a housing development. Metcalfe's conversation with Hodge follows the template of the one he just had with Peabury fairly closely; they both end up placing the blame and the responsibility to act on Metcalfe's shoulders. The Hornbeams also resign themselves to being dependent on Metcalfe's actions. Metcalfe, of course, wants to avoid this responsibility by appealing to bureaucracy. In short, much of the comedy in this section comes from the gentry's avoidance of what they see as their "duty," as well as their drawn-out, ineffective meetings about the best course of action.



The neighbors convene at Lady Peabury's house, underlining her status as the de facto leader of the group. All of the neighbors seem willing to hear Metcalfe's proposal, but once he reveals that he wants them to split the cost, their tenuous cooperation splinters. They've all attended the meeting in the spirit of self-interest, but as soon as Metcalfe asks them to contribute to the effort, they scatter—they expected Metcalfe to pay for the land himself. Intentionally or not, Metcalfe's wording does trap Peabury in the bargain, since she's too prideful and polite to admit that Metcalfe is actually richer than she is.



Ruffled and bitter, Peabury exchanges tense words with Metcalfe. Metcalfe informs her that he's not particularly attached to the idea of owning the field itself. Hodge points out that they ought to check that the land is for sale first, to which Peabury snipes that she looks forward to the outcome of Metcalfe's conversation with the seller. She immediately regrets her words, and sure enough, Metcalfe takes them as a grave insult. That evening, he decides to revert to his hard-nosed, stubborn persona from his days in the cotton business: "Metcalfe the lion of the Rotarians."

Peabury's words seem to insult Metcalfe in two ways: they (again) place the entire onus on him to strike a bargain with the new landowner, and they snottily call attention to his experience with negotiations from his business career. Her arrogance is the last straw for Metcalfe, who decides to embody exactly the stubborn businessman that she and the other neighbors mock. In this moment, Metcalfe abandons his goal of becoming a community-minded country gentleman and settles back into his profit-minded past.



Hodge feels disappointed in the day's events, realizing that Metcalfe is now going to dig in his heels and refuse to buy the land to spite Peabury. His wife suggests that he meet with the man who bought the land instead, and he does. Finding Mr. Hargood-Hood at the local inn, Hodge introduces himself and asks after Hargood-Hood's intentions with the land. Hargood-Hood is perfectly willing to converse with Hodge, and the Colonel discovers that he purchased the field through his lawyer as a site for industrial experiments—there will be two large chimneys, Hodge learns, because of the facility's poisonous fumes. Hodge reports this to Metcalfe, also mentioning that Hargood-Hood seemed generally agreeable and neutral to the idea of reselling.

When Hodge seeks out Hargood-Hood at his wife's suggestion, he finds a man who seems perfectly friendly and polite. Slowly, however, Hargood-Hood reveals his plan to develop the land into the absolute worst-case scenario. The chimneys in particular escalate the issue from a cosmetic or class-based one into an environmental crisis, endangering everything that makes the countryside appealing to its upper-class residents.



PART 3

The third part of the story takes an epistolary form. In a short letter, Metcalfe informs Peabury that he is in touch with Hargood-Hood and that the necessary funds to buy the land total £500—a £330 increase from the price when Metcalfe first moved to the village. He makes his final offer: they can split the £500 exactly in half. If she refuses, Metcalfe will abandon his efforts to save the land altogether and will sell his property so that it can be developed. In her reply, Peabury turns down the offer and dismisses his threats. Reading it, Metcalfe considers the matter closed.

The result of Metcalfe and Peabury's letters is essentially a stalemate over a petty issue. It's worth mentioning that Metcalfe's commitment to developing his own property represents a complete reversal of his principles: for all his talk of the greater good of the community and landscape, he is willing to compromise it entirely in order to make a point to one woman.



PART 4

Ten days later, Metcalfe and Peabury have both maintained their resolve to move out of Much Malcock, although they are wistful as they survey the landscape they're leaving. Metcalfe watches the **cows** and pictures the greenery wilting and dying in the industrial smog that Hargood-Hood's laboratory will create, and Peabury mourns the loss of her fine **gardens** and groves. Neither of them stands to benefit from relocation, since Metcalfe's threat of building his own housing estate on his land falls through and Peabury has little chance of finding another permanent home. Hodge and the Hornbeams are dejected with the state of affairs, and their mood seems to reach even Hargood-Hood, who sets out to have another conversation with Hodge.

In Part IV, all briefly appears lost. The situation is worse than ever, since Metcalfe and Peabury are both planning to sabotage the land for no personal gain. This section contains a eulogy of sorts to the valley, as Metcalfe and Peabury reflect on their connections to the land. Metcalfe compares himself to Westmacott's cattle, further developing their significance as a symbol of pastoral beauty and belonging. Peabury's focus on the gardens she has planted also revisits a symbol from Part II; in this section, she thinks of her garden as a marker of her long history as a steward of her land. In their feud, they are sacrificing their own hopes of acceptance and stability in the name of arrogant revenge.



PART 5

After Hargood-Hood and Hodge's talk, Hodge proposes a solution to Metcalfe: all of the neighbors can pitch in a bit of money to buy Hargood-Hood's land and build a new hut for the Boy Scouts upon it. Everyone is amenable to the idea of using the land for the public good. Ultimately, Peabury contributes £250 and Metcalfe £500, and everyone else a negligible amount. When the hut is finished, they name it the Metcalfe-Peabury Hall, and Mr. Metcalfe likes this so much that he convinces the local inn to change its name from "the Brakehurst Arms" to "the Metcalfe Arms."

This compromise works because it satisfies Metcalfe and Peabury's pride. By putting the land to public use, this arrangement allows both of them to avoid the awkwardness of contributing to the other's holdings while helping them appear selfless and altruistic. Ultimately, it is their dislike of one another, their prioritization of themselves, and their desire to come across as generous that brings the neighbors together. Of course, this compromise is expensive, as Metcalfe ends up spending at least twice as much as he ever planned to and developing the very land that he had wanted to keep unspoiled. For him, however, it is worth it to see his name gain significance and authority within Much Malcock. Through a combination of his cotton money, his pettiness, and his arrogance, he is finally able to become the country gentleman he has aspired to be.



In its final subsection, the story gets its punchline: Mr. Hargood-Hood is no London gentleman, but rather an old-money countryman himself. In order to preserve his own family estate, he and his brother—who masquerades as his lawyer—buy land in "unspoilt, well-loved village[s]," strike fear in the hearts of its residents with their supposed plans to develop industrial monstrosities, and sell the land back for a profit. The brothers congratulate each other on a job well done—although it was a bit of a close call—and start to look for their next target.

Mr. Hargood-Hood is just like the other characters in "An Englishman's Home"—he is a country gentleman. The fact that he is the opposite of what he pretended to be speaks to a larger pattern of disguise throughout the story. That is, neither the characters nor their motives are ever quite what they claim to be. In the end, their preservation efforts are always selfish, and in that, they are all more alike than they realize.





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